first explicitly recognize China's absolute and unconditional sovereignty over Taiwan.

No compromise was made by the Chinese on this principle, not with India in 1950 and not even with the United States of America in 1979, which was the most powerful nation at the time and the superpower with whom the Chinese desperately wanted to normalize relations. Sovereignty was a matter of principle for the Chinese that could not be sacrificed at any cost. On the other hand, the very same Chinese were proposing that India agree to China recognizing India's sovereignty and territorial integrity in an indirect way via a border trade agreement! That too with regard to a state over which India had exercised total sovereignty since 1975. This was not a question of tilting at windmills like some Don Quixote; it involved the principle of sovereignty. It was therefore important, and necessary, to insist that China should follow their own principle by explicitly recognizing Indian sovereignty over Sikkim before the opening of border trade and other exchanges.

Following the visit of External Affairs Minister Jaswant Singh to China, and as agreed by both sides, a mechanism was set up to begin negotiations on the text of a border trade agreement. In any negotiation, the written word matters, more so for the Chinese who have a long tradition of recording history unlike the *shruti* or oral tradition in India. The Chinese are skilful at manipulating words and their meanings; the possibility of a word or phrase having more than one meaning or being ambiguous, needs to be carefully parsed in a negotiation with the Chinese. The text of the border trade agreement suggested by the Chinese side contained the phrase 'border pass'. Prima facie this met Indian concerns. Except that the words 'border pass', unless it was qualified by reference to a particular geography, need not necessarily refer only to its location being on the India–China border; it was also open to being interpreted